

PASHTO PROVERBS

"A few words can carry generations of experience."

Some knowledge is written in books. Some is carried in conversations. A proverb can travel from a grandmother to a child, from a father to a son, from a neighbour to a neighbour, and from one generation to the next without ever being written down. A few words can contain a warning. A sentence can carry humor. A familiar expression can preserve an observation about human nature. For Pashto-speaking communities, proverbs form part of a wider oral tradition in which language carries experience. For the Orakzai, these expressions may live in family conversations, village memory, gatherings and everyday speech. But language crosses boundaries. A proverb spoken in Orakzai may also be known elsewhere in the Pashto world. The task is therefore not to claim every saying as uniquely Orakzai. It is to understand what the words mean, where they are documented, how they travel, and what they reveal about the people who use them.

PASHTO PROVERBS

"A few words can carry generations of experience."



"The convergence of written record, oral speech, and ancestral landscape."

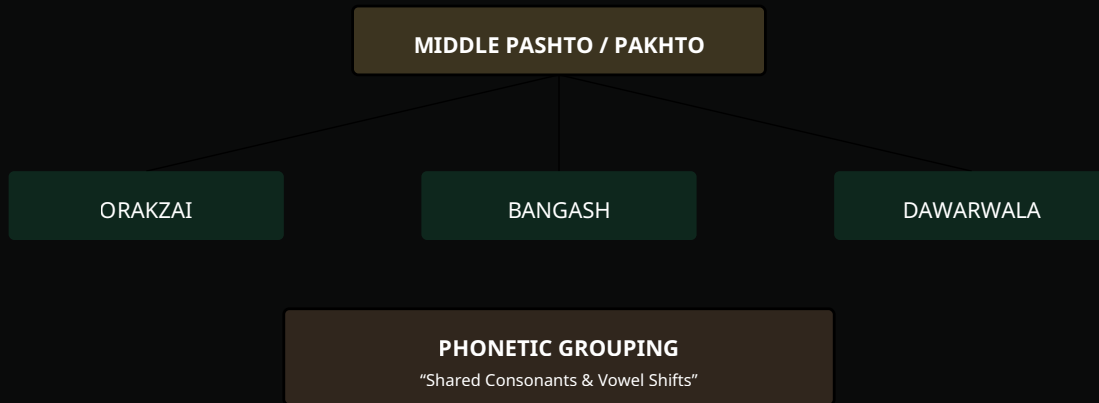
WHAT IS A PROVERB?

Academically, a proverb is a short, conventional expression that communicates wisdom, observation, advice, warning, humor, or social commentary. Proverbs are the distilled essence of a community's shared experience, refined through repetition and transmission over centuries. They are context-dependent, meaning their interpretation can shift based on the speaker, the audience, and the situation.

EXPERIENCE → LANGUAGE → SHORT EXPRESSION → MEMORY → REPETITION

"The formation of proverbial wisdom."

Orakzai Pashto belongs to the **Middle Pashto** or **Pakhto** dialect group, sharing phonetic characteristics with the dialects of Bangash and Dawarwala. This regional grouping is characterized by specific vowel shifts and consonant realizations. While many proverbs are Pashtun-wide, the way they are spoken in Orakzai reflects the unique linguistic landscape of the district.²



“The linguistic placement of the Orakzai dialect.”

CURATED COLLECTION: THEMATIC PROVERB GRID

The following proverbs are curated from academic collections, including **Rohi Mataluna** (Tair & Edwards, 2009). They represent the core themes of Pashtun and Orakzai oral wisdom.

WISDOM

وخت د هر غم دوا دی

Wakt da har gham dawa day.

“Time is the medicine for every grief.”

An observation on the healing nature of time and the necessity of patience in facing loss.

HONOR / GHAI RAT

د ښځې ستر د سړي غیرت دی

Da khaze satra da nari ghairat de.

“A woman's modesty is a man's honor.”

Reflects the cultural linkage between gendered social behavior and collective tribal honor (Nang).

HOSPITALITY

اول اطعام، پسې کلام

Awal ataam, pase kalaam.

“First food, then talk.”

A fundamental rule of hospitality: a guest's physical needs must be met before engaging in business or conversation.

PATIENCE

صبر تلخ دی خو میوه یې خوږه ده

Sabr talkh day kho mewa ye khozha da.

“Patience is bitter but its fruit is sweet.”

Encourages endurance through hardship with the promise of future reward.

ORIGIN / LINEAGE

اصل ته خطا نشته، کم اصل ته وفا نشته

Asal ta khata nishta, kam asal ta wafa nishta.

“No error in the original, no loyalty in the base.”

Stresses the importance of noble lineage and the belief that character is rooted in ancestry.

HOME / PATRIOTISM

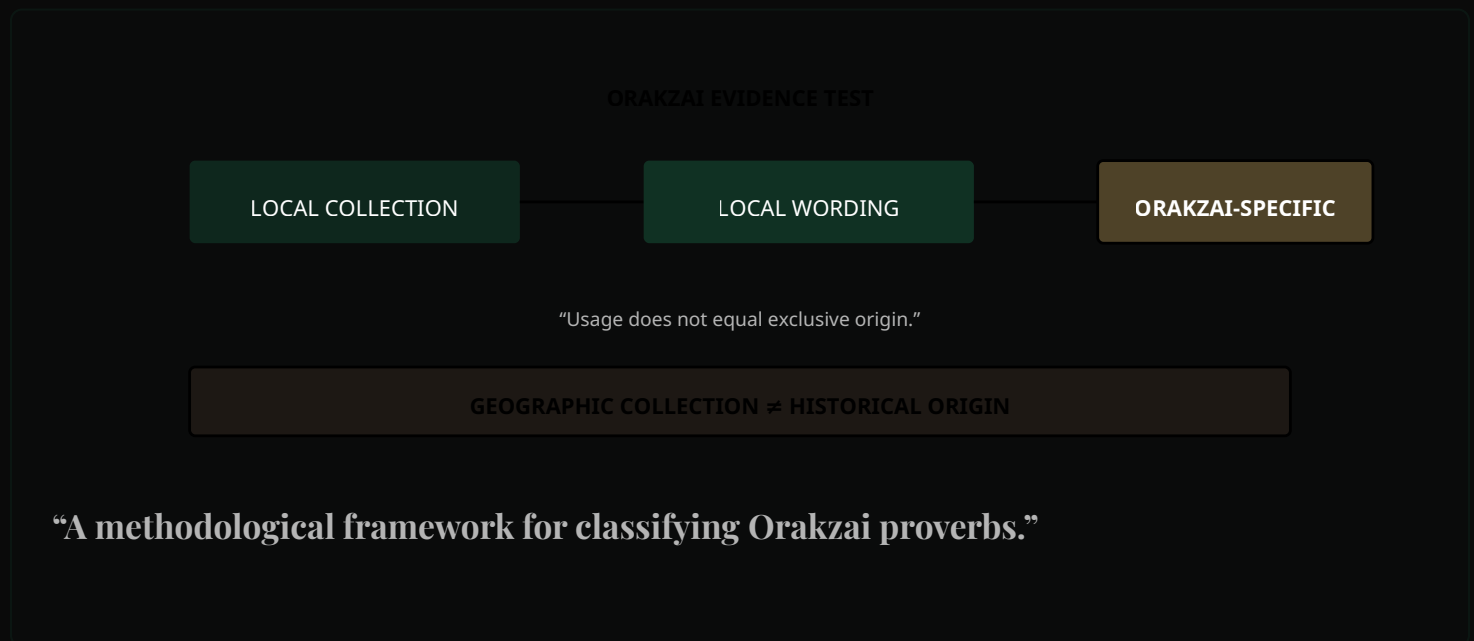
Har chata khpal watan kashmir de.

“For everyone, their own country is Kashmir.”

Expresses deep love for one's homeland, regardless of its challenges; Kashmir is used as a metaphor for paradise.

EVIDENCE TEST: IS IT ORAKZAI-SPECIFIC?

Direct evidence for a distinct, documented Orakzai proverb corpus remains limited. Most sayings used in Orakzai communities belong to the broader Pashto oral tradition. A proverb collected in Orakzai is evidence of its **usage** there, but not necessarily of its **exclusive origin**.



AI AND ORAL TRADITION: AI must not be used to invent proverbs or origins. While it can assist in translation and classification, the authority of oral tradition rests with the community and documented scholarship.

WHAT STILL NEEDS TO BE DOCUMENTED?

A systematic oral-history and linguistic project could help determine which expressions are widely Pashto, which are regionally concentrated, and whether a distinct Orakzai proverb

corpus can be documented. Future research should focus on village-level variations and Tirah-related expressions.

RESEARCH GAPS

- Orakzai-specific proverb corpus
- Women's oral traditions
- Village-level dialect variations
- Disappearing agricultural sayings
- Tirah-related expressions
- Digital transformation of proverbs

"Systematic documentation is required to map the local corpus."

"A roadmap for future linguistic and ethnographic research."

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

Proverbs are the quietest way a people remembers itself. They are the compact containers of wisdom that survive displacement, migration, and change. When an Orakzai elder speaks a proverb, they are not just using language; they are invoking the collective memory of the valley. While many of these sayings belong to the broader Pashtun world, their usage in Orakzai family life makes them ours. A proverb is not a law, but a cultural expression—a way to understand what we value, what we fear, and what we consider worth passing on to the next generation. As long as these words are spoken, the memory of our ancestors remains alive in our conversations.

"WORDS ARE THE DISTILLED ESSENCE OF MEMORY."

AUTHOR'S SYNTHESIS

